Medicapedia

History of medicine in the classroom

Printable worksheets by era, with activities and answers

Eight worksheets, one per era, to teach the history of medicine in class (ages 12 and up). Each worksheet has a timeline, key figures, a curiosity and three activities. Answers are at the end. Free Medicapedia material: you may print it and hand it out freely in class.

1/8 Antiquity to 476

Timeline

Key figures

- **Galen** (129–300)
- **Sextus Empiricus** (200–300)
- **Imhotep** (2800 BC–2700 BC)
- **Erasistratus** (305 BC–248 BC)
- **Herophilos** (334 BC–279 BC)
- **Charaka** (50)

Did you know?: Wounds as windows

Galen called the wounds of gladiators windows into the body, because they let him observe organs and tissues he could not otherwise see. *(Galen)*

Activities

1. Put these advances in order, from oldest to most recent.

2. Match each person with their contribution.

1. Galen	A. Systematic dissection
2. Sextus Empiricus	B. Pyrrhonian skepticism
3. Imhotep	C. Correction of Erasistratus
4. Erasistratus	D. Step Pyramid of Saqqara

3. Think and answer.

Which advance from this era seems most important to you today? Why?

Imagine you fall ill in this era: who would treat you and how would they cure you?

More at medicapedia.org/en/e/antiguedad.html

2/8 Middle Ages and Islam 476–1453

Timeline

Key figures

- **Avicenna** (980–1037)
- **Averroes** (1126–1198)
- **Moshe ben Maimon** (1138–1204)
- **Al-Biruni** (973–1048)
- **Abu Bakr al-Razi** (866–925)
- **Abu al-Qasim al-Zahrawi** (936–1036)

Did you know?: Memorising the Quran

He is said to have memorised the entire Quran by the age of ten. The sources pass this on as tradition, and it cannot be confirmed from contemporary documents. *(Avicenna)*

Activities

1. Put these advances in order, from oldest to most recent.

2. Match each person with their contribution.

1. Avicenna	A. Commentaries on Aristotle
2. Averroes	B. Mishneh Torah
3. Moshe ben Maimon	C. Earth's radius
4. Al-Biruni	D. The Canon of Medicine

3. Think and answer.

Which advance from this era seems most important to you today? Why?

Imagine you fall ill in this era: who would treat you and how would they cure you?

More at medicapedia.org/en/e/edad-media.html

3/8 # Renaissance 1453–1600

Timeline

Key figures

- **Andreas Vesalius** (1515–1564)
- **Nostradamus** (1503–1566)
- **Paracelsus** (1493–1541)
- **Gerolamo Cardano** (1501–1576)
- **Gabriele Falloppio** (1523–1562)
- **Michael Servetus** (1511–1553)

Did you know?: A book burned in the market square

According to the sources, on 23 June 1527 he burned a copy of Avicenna's Canon of Medicine in the market square of Basel, one of the core works of medical teaching. *(Paracelsus)*

Activities

1. Put these advances in order, from oldest to most recent.

2. Match each person with their contribution.

1. Andreas Vesalius	A. Almanacs of prophecy
2. Nostradamus	B. De humani corporis fabrica
3. Paracelsus	C. Ars magna (1545): a book that published the solutions to cubic and quartic equations and introduced imaginary numbers.Liber de ludo aleae
4. Gerolamo Cardano	D. Astrum in corpore

3. Think and answer.

Which advance from this era seems most important to you today? Why?

Imagine you fall ill in this era: who would treat you and how would they cure you?

More at medicapedia.org/en/e/renacimiento.html

4/8 Scientific Revolution 1600–1750

Timeline

Key figures

- **Carl Linnaeus** (1707–1778)
- **John Locke** (1632–1704)
- **Antonie van Leeuwenhoek** (1632–1723)
- **Marcello Malpighi** (1628–1694)
- **Pieter van Musschenbroek** (1692–1761)
- **Herman Boerhaave** (1668–1738)

Did you know?: A surname from a tree

His father took the surname Linnaeus from a large lime tree that grew on the family land. In Swedish, lime tree is lind. *(Carl Linnaeus)*

Activities

1. Put these advances in order, from oldest to most recent.

2. Match each person with their contribution.

1. Carl Linnaeus	A. Blood capillaries
2. John Locke	B. Observation of microorganisms
3. Antonie van Leeuwenhoek	C. Binomial nomenclature
4. Marcello Malpighi	D. Tabula rasa

3. Think and answer.

Which advance from this era seems most important to you today? Why?

Imagine you fall ill in this era: who would treat you and how would they cure you?

More at medicapedia.org/en/e/revolucion-cientifica.html

5/8 Enlightenment 1750–1830

Timeline

Key figures

- **Luigi Galvani** (1737–1798)
- **Edward Jenner** (1749–1823)
- **Franz Anton Mesmer** (1734–1815)
- **René Laennec** (1781–1826)
- **Heinrich Wilhelm Olbers** (1758–1840)
- **Samuel Hahnemann** (1755–1843)

Did you know?: A reading behind Frankenstein

Mary Shelley cited Galvani's reports among the readings that preceded the ghost-story contest in Switzerland that led to her novel Frankenstein. In the book, Victor studies galvanism, but the principle is not linked to the creation of the creature. *(Luigi Galvani)*

Activities

1. Put these advances in order, from oldest to most recent.

2. Match each person with their contribution.

1. Luigi Galvani	A. Animal magnetism
2. Edward Jenner	B. Animal electricity
3. Franz Anton Mesmer	C. Smallpox vaccine
4. René Laennec	D. Stethoscope

3. Think and answer.

Which advance from this era seems most important to you today? Why?

Imagine you fall ill in this era: who would treat you and how would they cure you?

More at medicapedia.org/en/e/ilustracion.html

6/8 The century of microbes 1830–1900

Timeline

Key figures

- **Sigmund Freud** (1856–1939)
- **Ivan Pavlov** (1849–1936)
- **Robert Koch** (1843–1910)
- **Élie Metchnikoff** (1845–1916)
- **Thomas Hunt Morgan** (1866–1945)
- **Louis Pasteur** (1822–1895)

Did you know?: A crater named after him

A small impact crater on the Moon, on a plateau within Oceanus Procellarum, bears the name Freud in his honour. *(Sigmund Freud)*

Activities

1. Put these advances in order, from oldest to most recent.

2. Match each person with their contribution.

1. Sigmund Freud	A. Koch's postulates
2. Ivan Pavlov	B. Phagocytosis
3. Robert Koch	C. Psychoanalysis
4. Élie Metchnikoff	D. Classical conditioning

3. Think and answer.

Which advance from this era seems most important to you today? Why?

Imagine you fall ill in this era: who would treat you and how would they cure you?

More at medicapedia.org/en/e/microbios.html

Twentieth century 1900–2000

Timeline

Key figures

- **Alexander Fleming** (1881–1955)
- **Gerty Cori** (1896–1957)
- **Alexis Carrel** (1873–1944)
- **Albert Szent-Györgyi** (1893–1986)
- **James Watson** (1928–2025)
- **Frederick Banting** (1891–1941)

Did you know?: Paintings made with germs

It is said that Fleming was admitted to the Chelsea Arts Club after presenting pictures painted with pigmented bacteria, invisible at first and visible once they grew. *(Alexander Fleming)*

Activities

1. Put these advances in order, from oldest to most recent.

2. Match each person with their contribution.

1. Alexander Fleming	A. Cori cycle
2. Gerty Cori	B. Vitamin C
3. Alexis Carrel	C. Vascular suture
4. Albert Szent-Györgyi	D. Penicillin (1928): a substance produced by a mould that destroyed bacteria, opening the era of antibiotics.Lysozyme (1921): a natural enzyme with antibacterial action, found in bodily secretions.Refusal to patent

3. Think and answer.

Which advance from this era seems most important to you today? Why?

Imagine you fall ill in this era: who would treat you and how would they cure you?

More at medicapedia.org/en/e/siglo-xx.html

8/8 Twenty-first century since 2000

Timeline

Key figures

- **Karl Deisseroth** (1971)
- **Li Wenliang** (1986–2020)

Did you know?: Kyoto Prize

In 2018 he received the Kyoto Prize, regarded as Japan's highest private award. At that point he became its youngest laureate to date. *(Karl Deisseroth)*

Activities

1. Put these advances in order, from oldest to most recent.

2. Match each person with their contribution.

1. Karl Deisseroth	A. Early warning
2. Li Wenliang	B. Optogenetics

3. Think and answer.

Which advance from this era seems most important to you today? Why?

Imagine you fall ill in this era: who would treat you and how would they cure you?

More at medicapedia.org/en/e/hoy.html

Answers

1. Antiquity

1.

2. 1-C · 2-B · 3-D · 4-A

2. Middle Ages and Islam

1.

2. 1-D · 2-A · 3-B · 4-C

3. Renaissance

1.

2. 1-B · 2-A · 3-D · 4-C

4. Scientific Revolution

1.

2. 1-C · 2-D · 3-B · 4-A

5. Enlightenment

1.

2. 1-B · 2-C · 3-A · 4-D

6. The century of microbes

1.

2. 1-C · 2-D · 3-A · 4-B

7. Twentieth century

1.

2. 1-D · 2-A · 3-C · 4-B

8. Twenty-first century

1.

2. 1-B · 2-A

3. Think and answer. —